about it. There was no sign of Dada. ‘No. No!’ I struggled to keep my grip. The other two boys came forward to help the sardar boy. But muscle finally won against might. The three of them held me back, both my arms in their tight grip and pushed me so hard that I fell to the ground, and took two rolls before I stopped. I felt a sharp pain in my right knee. Slowly, I got up, sat on the ground and hugged my knees against my chest. Blood oozed from the gash in my fingers as I held on to the scraped knee. The three boys let out a victorious laugh. I broke into loud sobs. There was still no sign of Dada.

Maa received a call from my teacher and came to school to pick me up. I was taken to the first aid room, where they dressed my wound. I’d told them all I had tripped and fallen. Dada would get a good scolding if I’d told them the truth. Maa took me home. I wasn’t crying any more. I was simply angry. Very angry.

‘Where were you?’ I asked Dada heatedly after he came home. Maa was in the kitchen. I was resting my leg on the sofa. Dada learnt about the entire incident from the other children in the school bus.

‘We were punished by Ms Geeta for not finishing our homework. She made us stand facing the wall for half of the recess,’ Dada said as he examined the dressing on my leg. He knew the wound was bad. It made him angry too.

‘Why did you not give them the swing? Why are you so stupid?’ he said.

‘Why are you shouting at me? I didn’t know you were not going to come,’ I replied.

‘How could you let yourself get hurt because of a swing, stupid?’ Dada’s concern frustrated him, and he stomped out of the living room.

As he left, Papaji entered. On seeing the dressing on my knee, he at once hung his beret on the stand and walked towards me. ‘What happened to my little girl?’ he crooned.

I hugged him and started to cry. ‘It’s okay. It’s just a scratch. You’re stronger than this,’ Papaji hugged me back. Maa had told Papaji everything on the telephone. For a while, I stayed in Papaji’s arms. He carefully lifted me and carried me to my room when he realized that I had fallen asleep. He